

Bitcoin Cash (BCH) Performance & Price Action (2017–Present)

Historical Momentum Summary

- **2017 Launch & Initial Pump:** Bitcoin Cash was born from an August 2017 Bitcoin hard fork focused on bigger blocks for cheaper transactions. In its first months, BCH surged above **\$700**, peaking near **\$4,000** in December 2017 during the crypto mania (while BTC hit ~\$20k) ¹. This initial spike was driven by excitement over “the new Bitcoin” narrative and every BTC holder suddenly owning BCH (supply airdropped).
- **2018 Crash & Fork Aftermath:** Like the broader market, BCH **collapsed in 2018**, sliding below **\$100** by late that year ². A **contentious fork in Nov 2018** split off *Bitcoin SV (BSV)*, dividing the community and adding sell-pressure uncertainty ². BCH kept its ticker on major exchanges, but the brand was dented. Another split hit in **Nov 2020** when the lead BCH developer group (*Bitcoin ABC*) forced a fork over a miner tax plan – the majority fork (*Bitcoin Cash Node*) retained the *BCH* name, while the minority chain (later *eCash*) faded out. These internal wars eroded confidence.
- **2021 Bull Run Rebound:** BCH rode the 2020–2021 bull cycle up to about **\$1,500** in May 2021 ³, a strong rebound but **still far below its 2017 ATH**. By this point BCH had underperformed Bitcoin in the long run (never revisiting four-figure prices after 2021). The 2021 rally was driven by general crypto liquidity and some renewed interest in “fast payments” narrative, but it lagged hotter sectors like DeFi.
- **Post-2021 Trends:** Since 2021, BCH's price has largely **tracked broader market cycles** – rising during crypto rallies and selling off in risk-off periods – but with extra volatility due to its smaller market cap ⁴. For example, in **June 2023** BCH suddenly **spiked 100%+ in a week**, jumping from ~\$100 to over \$250 after the new EDX Markets exchange (backed by Fidelity/Schwab) listed BCH (one of only four tokens) ⁵ ⁶. That listing signaled perceived regulatory safety for BCH, igniting a short-lived squeeze (Korean trading and FOMO drove volume). However, such rallies have often **fizzled** as traders take profit – BCH gave back a chunk of those 2023 gains afterward.
- **Macro/Regulatory Drivers:** Broadly, BCH's major moves have been catalyzed by ecosystem events. Positive drivers included Bitcoin's bull markets, exchange adoptions (e.g. PayPal support, EDX listing), and occasional payment adoption news. Negative drivers have been **contentious forks**, exchange delistings (OKCoin even delisted BCH in 2021 to avoid “Bitcoin” name confusion ⁷), and the fact that Bitcoin's own upgrades (SegWit, Lightning) and brand dominance stole BCH's thunder. Regulatory clarity has been a mixed bag – BCH was *not* labeled a security by U.S. regulators in 2023, which helped it avoid the fate of some alts, but it also hasn't seen any ETF/asset-manager demand to spark a sustained run. Overall, BCH has cycled through big pumps and deep drawdowns, with each successive peak lower than the last as its “digital cash” narrative struggled to regain the mainstream hype.

Devil's Advocate Take (Why BCH Underperformed)

BCH has **significantly underperformed** other majors like BTC and ETH since inception – at one point down ~97% vs Bitcoin from 2017 ⁸. Key factors often cited:

- **Brand Confusion & Reputation:** Bitcoin Cash inherited the Bitcoin name but not the trust. Many investors view it as an off-brand offshoot – even an exchange CEO delisted BCH partly to avoid newbies confusing it with BTC ⁷. The community infighting (multiple forks, public drama) hurt its credibility. In short, BTC won the “real Bitcoin” narrative, and BCH has struggled to differentiate itself ⁹.
- **Declining Network Usage:** Relative to smart contract platforms, BCH's on-chain activity is low. It's *mostly* used for simple value transfers, with **minimal DeFi or DApp ecosystem**. For example, daily DEX volumes and fees on BCH are negligible ¹⁰. Merchant adoption remains niche and concentrated in a few regions. Fewer users means less organic demand – a “**network effect**” gap versus ETH or even Litecoin.
- **Loss of Miner Support:** BCH uses the same SHA-256 mining algorithm as Bitcoin, but only ~4-5 EH/s of hashpower secures it (vs **Bitcoin's ~350+ EH/s**). This is <5% of total SHA-256 hash – essentially leftover or opportunistic mining ¹¹. Over time, many miners stuck with BTC's higher profitability and stability. Lower hash rate not only raises 51% attack concerns but also signals that miners (who once backed BCH's vision) largely **returned to Bitcoin**.
- **Technology Stagnation:** Aside from bigger blocks and the 2023 *CashTokens* upgrade, BCH hasn't seen groundbreaking new tech to attract builders. There's no native DeFi boom, no NFTs craze, no major layer-2s – meanwhile competitors innovated (e.g. Ethereum's move to proof-of-stake, Solana's high TPS, even Litecoin's MimbleWimble privacy). BCH's value prop of “fast, cheap payments” became less compelling as BTC fees dropped in quiet periods and as stablecoins/Lightning gained traction.
- **“Forgotten” Altcoin Status:** In market perception, BCH is often lumped with 2017-era alts that had their heyday and then faded. It lacks the meme appeal of Dogecoin, the platform utility of ETH, or the institutional backing of BTC. As one analysis put it: **adoption** is a critical weakness – BCH simply hasn't gained enough users or unique use-cases to drive a new growth cycle ¹² ¹³. This reputational overhang (seen as yesterday's fork story) makes investors rotate into trendier assets during bull runs, leaving BCH liquidity and momentum behind.

Bottom line: BCH's underperformance stems from being **outcompeted on brand, utility, and narrative**, despite its technical capability for payments. It's viewed as neither the safest store of value (BTC) nor the most innovative platform – a tough spot that has led to gradual relative decline.

Leverage and Speculation Snapshot

Futures positioning around BCH reveals cautious sentiment. *Perpetual swap* funding rates are **negative** at the moment – e.g. on Binance, the BCH funding is about **-0.024% per 8 hours** (shorts paying longs) ¹⁴. Several other exchanges show slightly negative to flat funding, indicating more short positions than longs in aggregate. This suggests many traders are betting on or hedging for BCH downside in the short term.

Open interest in BCH futures is moderate. Currently it's roughly **\$377 million** in notional OI across major exchanges ¹⁵. Notably, this is down over 10% in the last 24 hours ¹⁶, and down sharply from the mid-December peak. During the December price spike, BCH's OI ballooned to about **\$786M** as longs piled in ¹⁷.

Since then, OI has nearly halved – a sign of **de-leveraging** as those speculative longs were trimmed or liquidated when the rally cooled off.

The **sentiment signal** here is mixed: on one hand, falling OI and mild backwardation imply traders aren't aggressively bullish right now. On the other, the current **short bias** (negative funding) could set the stage for a mini short-squeeze. If any positive catalyst or buyer momentum emerges, crowded shorts may rush to cover, adding fuel to a rebound. Overall, the **funding and OI trend** indicates sentiment is leaning bearish/hesitant on BCH, with traders recently unwinding longs after the run-up. It's a *de-leveraging phase*, which could precede a more balanced market – or, if funding stays negative, it means contrarians have an incentive to pop a squeeze.

In summary: **derivatives traders are cautious**, and possibly positioning for further underperformance (or hedging exposure), as BCH lacks a strong bullish narrative at the moment. But any surprise strength could catch shorts offside given the build-up of bearish bets.

ETF and Institutional Influence (if any)

Unlike Bitcoin or Ethereum, **Bitcoin Cash has seen little direct ETF or institutional demand**. There is no U.S. spot BCH ETF, and it's generally *not* included in the high-profile crypto index funds beyond a token small weight. Grayscale does operate a **Bitcoin Cash Trust (BCHG)**, but its usage has been limited – in fact BCHG shifted from trading at a premium to a **discount (~13% below NAV)** as early investors exited ¹⁸. This persistent discount signals lukewarm interest from institutional buyers; BCHG isn't soaking up supply the way GBTC did for Bitcoin.

At times, BCH has been part of broader crypto ETPs (for example, some European ETPs or the Bitwise 10 large-cap index historically). But any **ETF-related flows** have been trivial compared to the tidal wave into Bitcoin or even secondarily into Ethereum. The recent U.S. spot ETF approvals for BTC (and filings for ETH) did *not* extend to BCH. One positive nuance: BCH's inclusion on the EDX Markets exchange in 2023 (backed by Fidelity/Schwab) was interpreted as a sign it passed a regulatory bar (EDX only listed assets deemed commodities/not securities) ⁶. However, that's more about clearance than about *active* institutional buying.

Another quasi-institutional factor is the **Mt. Gox rehabilitation**: creditors of Mt. Gox will eventually receive a distribution of BCH (since they held BTC at the 2014 collapse and thus got equivalent BCH from the fork). Around **137k BCH** (same count as BTC) are slated for release to claimants ⁸. Many expect that those creditors could sell their BCH for liquidity, which is an *overhang* of supply on the horizon. Sygnum Bank analysts noted this impending distribution and the fact BCH has "lost prominence" – underperforming BTC by 97% since 2017 – as reasons BCH may face **supply pressure** ahead ⁸.

In terms of **corporate or institutional treasuries**, BCH has virtually none to speak of. Companies like MicroStrategy bought BTC, not BCH. And while BCH is supported on retail fintech apps (PayPal, etc.), the volumes are small. No major institution has publicly allocated to BCH as a distinct investment. The **Grayscale BCH Trust** holds some coins but its AUM is minor (and it even faced selling during the 2022–2023 crypto downturn).

Bottom line: BCH hasn't benefited from the ETF fervor or institutional adoption wave. It's viewed as a more **retail-driven asset**. The one institutional angle to watch is that any future index or fund including "the top 5-10 cryptos" might include BCH – but even that would be a niche allocation. In the meantime, looming events like the Mt. Gox coin release are more likely to introduce *sell* flows than massive buy pressure from big players.

Altcoin Relative Strength

Over the **past month**, Bitcoin Cash has been an *average performer* among majors – slightly up, but lagging the hottest coins. BCH is **up ~5-6% in the last 30 days**, which actually outpaced Bitcoin's modest +2% move ¹⁹. It also did a bit better than Ethereum (which was roughly flat to slightly down over the month) ²⁰. However, BCH's monthly gain is on par with other "older" cryptos: Litecoin (LTC) was roughly flat to +1% in the same period, and *Solana (SOL)* – a much newer L1 – gained about **+4%** ²¹. In other words, BCH isn't showing dramatic strength or weakness; it's chugged along with mid-single-digit upticks.

Zooming out, the **market trend has favored Bitcoin** lately. Bitcoin's dominance is around **57%** of total crypto market cap ²² – near the highest level in several years. When BTC dominance rises, it usually means altcoins as a whole are underperforming BTC. BCH, being a legacy alt, often *loses ground* in BTC-led rallies (investors rotate to the safety and liquidity of BTC). Indeed, despite BCH's USD price being up over the year, its ratio against BTC is near historic lows.

One could call BCH a "**legacy altcoin**" that hasn't enjoyed the kind of narrative boost some newer alts saw. For instance, in the past month **SOL** and certain AI or Layer2 tokens had bursts of outperformance beyond what BCH achieved. Even **Litecoin** tends to get a halving narrative pump (as it did in mid-2023) that BCH lacks. That said, BCH did hold its own against ETH and LTC recently, indicating that among the *2017-era cohort* it moves largely in tandem. Its relative strength versus *Bitcoin* over longer periods remains poor (e.g. BCH/BTC is down significantly year-on-year, reflecting Bitcoin's flight to quality).

With **BTC dominance high and climbing**, BCH's role is somewhat sidelined. It's not capturing major new investment flows, and its rank has fluctuated around the lower end of the top 15 by market cap. When the market goes "risk on" broadly, BCH can and does ride along (as seen in its ~30% gain in 2025 overall). But when the market narrows to Bitcoin (or a few narratives), BCH tends to **lag**. In sum, its *relative strength* recently is middling – better than some laggards, but clearly not a leadership asset in the current market regime.

Recent News Events (30-Day Highlights)

- **Derivatives-Fueled Rally (Dec 19, 2025) – Positive Short-Term:** BCH's price **jumped ~10% within 24 hours** on Dec 19 as a wave of futures buying hit. Perpetual swap traders turned aggressively long, pushing open interest up by **\$184M** in a day (to about \$786M OI total) ¹⁷. Funding flipped positive as longs paid shorts, and ~\$2.5M in short liquidations were recorded. This leverage-driven spike was a *short-term bullish* catalyst (essentially a mini short-squeeze and momentum trade). It also coincided with BCH approaching a technical breakout level (~\$600) in a bullish triangle pattern, adding to trader optimism.
- **Spot Selling Into Strength (Late Dec 2025) – Neutral/Negative:** On that same rally, on-chain data showed some **holders selling into the pump**. Around **\$3.9M BCH flowed to exchanges** on Dec 19

²³ – reversing what had been an accumulation trend earlier in the month. Over the week following, about \$4–5M net BCH was sent to exchanges, presumably to take profits. This implies that while speculators were driving the price up, some long-term holders used the higher prices as an exit opportunity. It put a bit of a damper on the sustainability of the rally (a slight negative for sentiment, as it suggested a lack of broad confidence at levels above \$600).

- **Profit-Taking Dip (Jan 6–7, 2026) – Negative:** After a strong year-end, BCH saw a **5%+ weekend drop in early January**. This pullback was largely attributed to **profit-taking** and a classic “*buy the rumor, sell the news*” event fade ²⁴. BCH had been one of 2025’s better performers among alts (up over 30% on the year), so once the New Year hit, some traders rotated out. There was also chatter that a scheduled minor upgrade had occurred and the excitement around it evaporated. The key point: this drawdown highlighted BCH’s tendency to **spike on anticipation and then bleed off** – a pattern seen after past forks and announcements as well. It was a short-term setback that turned the momentum bearish going into mid-January.
- **No Major Protocol Updates (recent – Neutral):** In the past month, there haven’t been significant **development news** or new partnerships for BCH. (The last major protocol upgrade was in May 2023, which introduced CashTokens for tokenization on BCH.) The network has been running smoothly without drama recently – which is good for stability, but it also means *no fresh catalyst* from the dev side. This neutral technical backdrop means price has been driven mostly by market dynamics rather than fundamentals lately.
- **General Crypto Market News (Neutral for BCH):** Broader developments like Bitcoin ETF progress, macroeconomic news, or altcoin regulatory updates have affected sentiment, but none singled out BCH specifically. One noteworthy point was **Bitcoin’s relative weakness in late December** which saw some funds rotate into large-cap alts like BCH briefly (hence BCH’s outperformance on certain days). Additionally, *Bitcoin Cash was mentioned* in some year-end analyst reports as a “payment coin to watch,” but these had no immediate impact. Overall, BCH’s news flow was **quiet**, with the price mostly moving on technical trading and broader crypto sentiment.

Net assessment: The past month had **one big positive jolt** (derivatives-fueled rally), but that was tempered by insiders selling and by a subsequent cool-off. No transformative news (like ETF inclusion or major adoption deal) hit BCH in this period. The news we do have paints a picture of BCH being used as a *trading vehicle* – quick to pump on speculation, and quick to see selling on strength.

Market Regime Label

Legacy altcoin lagging amid a Bitcoin-dominated market. (*BCH remains a 2017-era “digital cash” coin that is currently overlooked – it rises and falls with crypto tides, but isn’t leading the pack in this BTC-driven cycle.*)

Current BCH Price for Context

As of now, **Bitcoin Cash (BCH) is trading around \$605–\$610 USD** per coin ²⁵. This is roughly +36% year-on-year, but still over 80% below its 2017 all-time high – highlighting the long-term lag even as it sees short-term oscillations around the six hundred dollar level.

5 6 **Bitcoin Cash (BCH) Surges 33.9% in 24 Hours on EDX Listing, S. Korean Trading Spike - Decrypt**
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